On the other hand, Hindu Shahis still did not give up the fight and they kept defending through Gandhara against the eastern expansion of Islam till AD 1026.

The belt of Afghanistan what we see today had been resisting Islamic expansion till the early centuries and the *Dharmik* traditions flourished there in different forms for quite longer than we tend to think.

The Chinese monk *Xuan Zang* reported in his travel diary that during the early 700s that Zabul was full of numerous Buddhist stupas which he postulated to have been built by Ashoka in the third century BC. He also reported about hundreds of Buddhist monasteries, and dozens of Hindu temples. He also speaks about the temple of Hindu god *Zun* (one destroyed by Samura) that drew many pilgrims. In the earlier section we also read about the Korean Buddhist monk Hyecho visited Zabulistan in AD 726 and recorded that Kābul and Zabul were ruled by Buddhist Turkic kings, who followed Buddhism. The last phase of the Tapa Sardar Buddhist monastery in Ghazni, dates to the time of the Zunbils (Afghanistan).

The resemblance with Hinduism and the tradition of Zunbils has already been discussed in the earlier sections but here again some points are added to corelate with the earlier reading. The Zunbils worshiped a deity called *Zhūn* (or *Zūn*), from whom they derived their name (Wink, 2002). He is represented with flames radiating from his head on coins. Statues were adorned with gold and used rubies for eyes which Huen Tsang had addressed as "*sunagir*" (Habibi).

Scholars have varied opinion about the origin and nature of Zhun yet all of them hint for it to be of Pagan nature. A study concludes that Zhun was possibly connected to the deity of the river Oxus, the modern river *Amudarya* and holds it most likely that Zhun was the greatest deity worshiped in Zabulistan. According to F. Grenet the Zhun might be related to the Iranian solar deity *Mithra* (A Unique Alxon-Hunnic Horse-and-Rider Statuette, (Late Fifth Century C E) from Ancient Bactria / Modern Afghanistan in the Pritzker Family Collection, Chicago, 2019). Zhun has been linked with the Hindu god *Aditya* at Multan, along with connection to pre-Buddhist religious and kingship practices of Tibet and Shaivism (Bosworth, 1977). Some scholars have proven with empirical evidence and epistemology that the cult of *Zhun* was primarily Hindu and can't be seen as either Buddhist or Zoroastrian. Scholars have also deliberated connections between the *Zhun/Zun* and the Hindu god *Shiva*, suggesting a syncretic mixture of the Iranian and Indian gods in the Indo-Iranian borderlands of ancient Bactria (Etymology of Zhunbil and Identity of the Rulers of Kabul and Zabul in Seventh -Ninth Centuries